

Kant — Answer-Writing Toolkit

Kant • Solved PYQs and Answer Writing

This is the topic's solved Mains/PYQ workbook and transfer manual. All **11 directly owned** verified PYQs through 2026 receive complete independent model answers. These are learner practice, never official UPSC answer keys. Hegel is retained inside routed comparisons; 2026 Q2(b) is cross-linked to Empiricism without duplicate ownership.

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What to recall and what to write

Demand	Recall first	Write for marks
Synthetic a priori	two crossed distinctions; Hume's fork	one example each; why ampliative and necessary; scope cost
Space and time	four metaphysical arguments; transcendental exposition	separate apriority from intuitivity; ideality with empirical reality
Categories/deduction	judgment table; twelve categories; "I think"	distinguish identification from justification; objective unity
Schematism/principles	temporal schema; all three Analogies	rule versus image; house/ship; objective time determination
Idealism/noumena	Refutation; inner/outer experience; negative noumenon	do not infer a hidden causal object; state empirical realism
Ideas/Dialectic	regulative/constitutive; soul, world, God	diagnose natural illusion; keep each failure mechanism distinct
Antinomies	four pairs; mathematical/dynamical	shared false premise; two different resolutions; freedom only thinkable
God-proofs	ontological, cosmological, design	show dependency chain; existence is not content-adding; bounded postulate
Kant-Hume/Hegel	precise predecessor position	establish the other thinker first where that thinker owns the question

Must-write keywords

Project: critical philosophy; transcendental not transcendent; quid juris; synthetic a priori; necessity; strict universality; change of standpoint; conditions of possible experience.

Aesthetic and Analytic: pure intuition; outer/inner sense; metaphysical/transcendental exposition; transcendental ideality; empirical reality; metaphysical/transcendental deduction; categories; synthesis; transcendental unity of apperception; *Ich denke*; schema; transcendental determination of time; principles; Analogies; permanence; causal succession; community.

Limit and Dialectic: Refutation of Idealism; appearance (*Erscheinung*); thing in itself; negative noumenon; limiting concept; Ideas of Reason; regulative/constitutive; transcendental illusion; Paralogisms; Antinomies; mathematical/dynamical; Ideal of Pure Reason; *ens realissimum*; existence is not a real predicate; postulates of practical reason.

High-value analytical lines

- A transcendental argument purchases necessity at the price of scope: its conclusion holds for objects as they can appear to us, not for things in themselves.
- The metaphysical deduction identifies the categories; the transcendental deduction justifies their objective validity.

- Apperception is a function of unified self-ascription, not an intuition of a soul-substance.
- Schematism is the bridge Kant's architecture requires and the mechanism it least transparently explains.
- The Second Analogy does not discover causal laws; it establishes rule-governed succession as a condition for distinguishing an event from a subjective sequence.
- Noumenon is safest as a negative limiting concept, not as a positively described hidden object.
- Antinomies arise when a regulative search for conditions is converted into a constitutive claim about a completed world-whole.
- Hegel culminates Kant's constitutive insight only by overcoming Kant's fixed boundary.

Introduction bank

1. "Kant's critical philosophy relocates necessity from objects or habit to the a priori conditions under which anything can count as an object for us."
2. "The *Critique of Pure Reason* has one positive and one negative task: to vindicate synthetic a priori cognition within experience and to discipline reason beyond it."
3. "Kant's settlement is empirical realism joined to transcendental idealism: appearances are publicly real, while their universal forms belong to our mode of cognition."

Conclusion bank

- "Kant secures objectivity not by reaching behind experience but by explaining its necessary form."
- "The doctrine succeeds as a boundary theory even where its inventory and mediation remain disputed."
- "Hegel preserves Kant's constitutive turn while rejecting the unknowable remainder that limits it."
- "The critique denies speculative proof, not the practical intelligibility of God, freedom and immortality."

Redrawable visuals and comparison axes

GIVEN manifold -> categories -> apperceptive unity -> temporal schemata
-> objective principles -> phenomenal nature

REASON: conditioned -> demand for unconditioned -> constitutive misuse
SOUL -> Paralogisms | WORLD -> Antinomies | GOD -> Ideal and failed proofs

Axis	Hume	Kant	Hegel
Necessity	mental expectation/custom	condition of possible experience	immanent necessity of the Concept
Categories	associations/conceptual habits	fixed a priori functions	self-developing determinations
Reality known	impressions and beliefs	appearances under forms/categories	reality as intelligible whole

Axis	Hume	Kant	Hegel
Limit	sceptical/naturalist restraint	thing in itself as boundary	fixed noumenal remainder rejected

Universal answer spine and rubric

10 marks: define -> reconstruct 2-3 moves -> qualification -> verdict
 15 marks: full argument -> restriction -> objection/reply -> graded judgement
 20 marks: architecture -> complete derivation/table -> criticism -> reply -> residual -> verdict

Score 0–2 on: exact demand; doctrinal accuracy; complete argument; A/B or textual anchor; restriction; objection and reply; useful visual/comparison; signed verdict; exam-length control. **14–16:** ready; **10–13:** repair named cells; **below 10:** return to the Revision Guide.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline — read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers; the 2018–2025 Paper I texts are held locally in books\philosophy_optional\, while 2026 Q4(b) was checked against the read-only OCR export of the official scan at knowledge-export\Mains PYQ\QP-CSM-26-010926-Optional-PHILOSOPHY-PAPER_I.pdf.md. Where an older mark column was unreliable, the mark value follows the repository's verified Western Philosophy PYQ ledger and is flagged. Doctrinal claims are attributed by **A/B pagination**, and interpretive disputes — whether transcendental idealism is a two-world or a two-aspect doctrine, whether the A- and B-Deductions argue differently, whether Kant's refutation reaches modal versions of the ontological argument — are flagged as contested rather than settled.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper I parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands are **10 marks — about 150 to 200 words**, **15 marks — about 250 to 300 words**, and **20 marks — about 340 to 400 words**. Every solution below sits inside its declared band, and the demand decoding, the verdict heading and the "why this earns marks" notes are teaching apparatus that sit **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage: eleven directly owned Kant PYQs from 2018 to 2026 — every primary-owned part the ledgers route to this syllabus item — and six original solved Mains models, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks. ⚠️

Corpus signal: Kant owns 10 of 112 Western Philosophy question-parts in the 2018–2025 corpus, and **2025 is the only year without a Kant-owned part**. Five further parts *name* Kant but are owned elsewhere — 2018 Q2(c) (Topic 11), 2020 Q2(a) and 2025 Q2(c) (Topic 03), 2025 Q1(e) (Topic 05), and 2026 Q2(b) (Topic 03) — and in each of those the owner's argument must be completed **before** Kant's reply is reported.

Citation discipline used in every answer. Kant is cited by A/B pagination: Bxvi–xviii (the change of standpoint), Bxxx ("deny knowledge... make room for faith"), Bxxxix n. ("scandal of philosophy"), B1 and B3–4 (the a priori and its marks), A51/B75 (empty thoughts, blind intuitions), B131–2 (the "I think"), A137–47/B176–87 (Schematism), A141/B180–1 ("an art concealed..."), A176/B219 and A183/B226 ("time itself cannot be perceived"), B218 (general principle of the Analogies), B224, A189–93/B232–8, B256 (the three Analogies), B274–9 (Refutation of Idealism), A598/B626 ("being is not a real predicate"). The *Prolegomena* (1783) is cited separately for Hume's interruption.

2018 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the significance of the Kantian dictum, 'Understanding makes Nature'. How far do you agree that Hegel's Absolutism is the culmination of the Kantian Dualism? Discuss. Give reasons in favour of your answer.

 **Marks note:** the local 2018 Paper I PDF renders the mark column unreliably; the 15-mark value follows the repository's verified PYQ ledger.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two limbs — "explain the significance", then "how far do you agree... give reasons"
Core issue	In what sense the understanding constitutes nature, and whether Hegel completes or overturns Kant
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the dictum with its restriction, three Hegelian moves, one ruling with reasons
Ideal thesis	Nature <i>formally</i> considered is constituted by the categories; Hegel radicalises constitutive idealism and simultaneously attempts to overcome Kant's limits
Non-negotiables	Form versus matter; universal law versus particular law; the three Hegelian moves; a distinction rather than a flat yes or no

Independent model answer

The dictum. The understanding "makes" nature **formally considered** — as the law-governed unity of appearances. Sensations alone are unordered; synthesis under the categories of substance, causality and community yields objects standing in objective temporal relations, and hence universal laws. Since the conditions of possible experience are also the conditions of the objects of experience, experienced nature necessarily conforms to them.

Its significance is threefold. It explains how the fundamental principles of natural science can be synthetic and yet a priori, since their necessity is contributed rather than discovered. It answers Hume without denying his analysis of impressions. And it fixes the limit precisely: what is constituted is form, not matter.

Three denials protect the claim. The understanding does not create the sensory manifold, which is received; it does not produce particular empirical laws, which remain empirical discoveries won by observation; and the constitution is transcendental and therefore public, not private imagination. Transcendental idealism is in this sense empirical realism.

Hegel. He accepts that thought is constitutive rather than a passive copy of a ready-made reality. He radicalises this by treating the categories as internally self-developing and contradiction as the motor of thought rather than a symptom of illegitimate transcendence. He rejects Kant's fixed oppositions — sensibility and understanding, phenomenon and noumenon, finite and unconditioned — and above all the unknowable thing in itself.

Verdict. ⚠️ Partially. Hegel is a culmination in extending constitutive idealism, but an attempted **overcoming** in rejecting Kant's limits. The gain is systematic unity; the cost is the stronger claim that dialectical reason knows the Absolute.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2018 Q2(b): the question has two limbs and a directive demanding reasons. A script that explains the dictum beautifully and then reports Hegel neutrally has answered one and a half questions.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: dictum in four lines; significance in three; denials in three; Hegel in three; ruling in two.

- **Structure:** doctrine → significance → denials → Hegel's three moves → distinguished verdict.
- **Doctrine:** categories as rules of objectivity; form versus matter; universal versus particular law.
- **Evidence:** the supreme principle that conditions of experience are conditions of its objects; the three Hegelian moves.
- **Distinction:** culmination in one sense, overcoming in another.
- **Criticism:** note that Hegel's gain in unity is bought by a claim Kant would call transcendent.

2019 · Q4(a) · 20 marks

Question: How does Kant argue for the transcendence of Space and Time? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does Kant argue" — reconstruct the argument , not the conclusion
Core issue	The a priori and intuitive status of space and time, and what it explains
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the wording caution, both expositions, the two rivals, the double result, one qualification
Ideal thesis	Two expositions with different jobs establish that space and time are pure forms of intuition, transcendently ideal and empirically real
Non-negotiables	"Transcendence" read correctly; four metaphysical arguments sorted into two pairs; geometry and arithmetic; Newton and Leibniz; ideality with reality

Independent model answer

⚠️ **A word first.** "Transcendence" here cannot mean existence beyond experience — that would be the *transcendent* error Kant attacks. It means the **a priori and transcendentally ideal** status of space and time, established by two expositions with different jobs.

Metaphysical exposition. Space is not derived from experience: to refer sensations to something outside me, or to represent things as beside one another, space must already be presupposed, so it is the condition and not the product of outer experience. Space is necessary: we may think it empty of objects but cannot think it away, whereas objects can always be thought away. These two arguments establish **apriority**.

Space is singular: there is only one space, and particular spaces are limitations within it, whereas a general concept has instances *under* it rather than parts *in* it. Space is given as an **infinite magnitude**: a concept may contain infinitely many representations under it, but no concept contains infinitely many within it. These two establish **intuitivity**. Space is therefore a *pure intuition*. Parallel arguments hold for time — succession and simultaneity presuppose it and cannot yield it; times are parts of one time; it is given as unlimited.

Transcendental exposition. This shows what the representation explains. Space grounds **geometry**: figures are constructed in pure intuition, so what is proved of the construction holds necessarily of every object of outer sense, since such objects can be given only under this form. Time grounds **arithmetic** and the pure doctrine of motion, since number is successive addition and alteration is possible only in time.

The two rivals fail. Newton's self-subsistent containers are two eternal non-entities that no experience could disclose and yet condition everything real. Leibniz's confused relations among things in themselves could never be known with necessity, so apodictic geometry would be lost. Both treat space as something *encountered*; Kant makes it the form of encounter.

Result. Transcendental **ideality** with empirical **reality**: nothing at all apart from our sensibility, yet objectively valid of every appearance without exception.

Verdict. ⚠️ The argument from geometry lapsed once geometry ceased to be uniquely Euclidean; the metaphysical exposition, and Kant's dissolution of the Newton–Leibniz dispute, survive intact.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2019 Q4(a): the first line must neutralise the word "transcendence". Everything after that is structure.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: caution in two lines; four metaphysical arguments in six; transcendental exposition in four; rivals in three; result in two; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** wording caution → metaphysical exposition sorted into two pairs → transcendental exposition → rivals → double result → qualification.
- **Doctrine:** forms of outer and inner sense; pure intuition; ideality and reality.
- **Evidence:** the four arguments; geometry and arithmetic as the explananda.
- **Distinction:** apriority established by arguments 1–2, intuitivity by 3–4.
- **Criticism:** non-Euclidean geometry damages the transcendental exposition, not the metaphysical one.

2020 · Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: When does Pure Reason enter into the realm of Antinomies according to Kant? Is Kant's notion of Antinomies of Pure Reason a natural culmination of his distinction between Phenomena and Noumena? Give reasons in favour of your answer.

⚠ **Marks note:** the local 2020 Paper I PDF renders the mark column unreliably; the 15-mark value follows the repository's verified PYQ ledger.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A "when" question, then a yes/no with reasons
Core issue	The trigger of antinomy, and whether the phenomena/noumena distinction causes or cures it
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the trigger, one example of the construction, the ruling, two reasons
Ideal thesis	Reason enters antinomy when the regulative demand for the unconditioned is read constitutively; the antinomies culminate transcendental realism about appearances , not Kant's distinction
Non-negotiables	"Given whole" as the shared false premise; the two resolutions; the corrected formulation of the second limb

Independent model answer

When. Pure reason enters antinomy when its legitimate search for conditions demands an **absolutely unconditioned, completed world-series** and then treats that totality as an object given in itself. Reason's principle — if the conditioned is given, the whole series of conditions is given — is a *maxim* of enquiry; read as a statement about an existing object, it generates conflict.

How the conflict is built. Each antinomy proves thesis and antithesis indirectly. Suppose the world has no beginning: an infinite series would already have been completed, which is impossible. Suppose it has a beginning: before it lay empty time, in which nothing can begin, since no part of empty time distinguishes existence from non-existence. Both proofs assume the world is a **given whole** of which one predicate must hold.

The ruling. ⚠ **No — not a culmination of the phenomena/noumena distinction.** The antinomies are the natural culmination of **transcendental realism about appearances**: they arise from *ignoring* the boundary, not from maintaining it.

Two reasons. First, the distinction is the **cure**. Once appearances are not things in themselves, the world-series is given only as a regress that may always be continued, so the mathematical antinomies dissolve with both sides false and the shared premise is exposed. Second, the distinction is what permits the dynamical resolution: natural determination holds of appearances while spontaneous causality remains thinkable of the same agent considered as noumenon.

Verdict. ⚠ Reason enters antinomy by hypostatizing a regulative demand; Kant's dualism resolves the conflict rather than producing it — and the antinomies thereby function as an indirect proof of transcendental idealism.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2020 Q3(c): the second limb invites an agreement that would invert Kant. Ruling first, then two independent reasons.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: trigger in four lines; construction in five; ruling in two; reasons in four; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** trigger → construction with one worked pair → ruling → two reasons → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** regulative versus constitutive; the given whole; the two resolutions.
- **Evidence:** the first antinomy's double *reductio*.
- **Distinction:** transcendental realism about appearances versus the phenomena/noumena boundary.
- **Criticism:** note the indirect-proof status, which is a strength and not a mere by-product.

2021 · Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain how Cartesian formulation of ontological argument is criticised by Kant.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain how" — exposition dominates, but the mechanism must be exhibited
Core issue	Why no analysis of a concept can yield existence
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: Descartes' version, the refutation, the thalers, the contradiction corollary
Ideal thesis	Existence posits rather than determines, so it cannot be one of the perfections contained in a concept
Non-negotiables	"Real predicate" glossed correctly; A598/B626; the thaler example used for the right point

Independent model answer

The Cartesian argument. God is the most perfect, most real being. Existence is a perfection. A being lacking existence would lack a perfection and so would not be the most perfect being. Therefore God necessarily exists. Descartes' image is that existence belongs to God's essence as three angles belong to a triangle.

Kant's refutation. "Being is obviously not a real predicate" (A598/B626). ⚠ *Real* here means **content-adding**, from *res* — a *Bestimmung*, a determination that enlarges a concept. It does not mean "concerning a real thing".

To say that something exists is not to add a property to its concept; it is to **posit** the concept's object, with all its predicates, as actual. Hence the thalers: "a hundred real thalers do not contain the least coin more than a hundred possible thalers." The concept is identical whether or not any thalers exist; what differs is my financial position, not my thought.

It follows that "existence" cannot appear among the perfections in the concept of God. The argument moves entirely inside the concept and never reaches outside it. However rich the concept, it determines only what God would be *if* God exists.

The corollary about contradiction. Descartes needs the denial to be self-contradictory. Kant answers that if we reject subject and predicate together — if there is no such being at all — nothing remains that could conflict. Contradiction arises only when a subject is retained and one of its genuine predicates denied, and existence is not that kind of predicate.

Verdict. ⚠️ Kant does not show God's non-existence; he shows that no concept, however perfect, can contain its own instantiation.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2021 Q2(c): "Explain how" rewards mechanism. The gloss on "real predicate" is where most scripts silently go wrong.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: argument in four lines; refutation in six; thalers in three; corollary in four; verdict in one.

- **Structure:** Descartes' version → the refutation → the illustration → the corollary → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** positing versus determining; *Bestimmung*.
- **Evidence:** A598/B626; the hundred thalers.
- **Distinction:** what a concept fixes versus whether anything answers to it.
- **Criticism:** the verdict marks the limit — non-provability, not non-existence.

2022 · Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: What is apperception, according to Immanuel Kant? Discuss with reference to his transcendental exposition of space and time.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Definition, then an explicit link to a <i>named</i> doctrine
Core issue	What apperception is, and how it stands to the forms of intuition
Scope boundary	Ten marks: definition, three negations, the architecture, one caution
Ideal thesis	Apperception is the formal condition that the "I think" can accompany all my representations; it unifies what sensibility supplies

Element	Requirement
Non-negotiables	The modal "must be able to"; function not substance; the architecture stated in the right order

Independent model answer

Definition. The transcendental unity of apperception is the formal condition that the representation "I think" (*Ich denke*) **must be able to** accompany all my representations (B131–2); otherwise something would be represented in me that could not be thought, and would be nothing *for me*.

What it is not. It is not an empirical self found by introspection — not Hume's bundle. It is not a soul-substance; inferring one is the Paralogism. It is *transcendental*, a condition of possibility, not *transcendent*.

Relation to space and time. Space and time supply the pure forms **in** which a manifold can be given; apperception supplies the requirement that this manifold be **combinable in one self-consciousness**; the categories are the rules of synthesis by which a manifold given in space and time is represented as an object for one "I think".

⚠ **The necessary caution.** The transcendental exposition does **not** itself deduce apperception. The architecture runs: the Aesthetic supplies the forms of intuition, the Deduction justifies the categories through apperceptive unity, the Schematism mediates their temporal application.

Verdict. ⚠ Apperception unifies what sensibility gives; it neither creates the sensible matter nor proves a soul.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2022 Q1(e): the examiner has named a doctrine, so the link must be explicit and correctly ordered. Reversing the architecture is the standard failure.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: definition in three lines; negations in three; architecture in four; caution in three; verdict in one.

- **Structure:** definition → negations → architecture → caution → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** original apperception; synthesis; transcendental versus transcendent.
- **Evidence:** B131–2 and the modal formulation.
- **Distinction:** condition of experience versus content within it.
- **Criticism:** the caution is itself the assessment, and it is what a ten-mark part can afford.

2022 · Q3(a) · 20 marks

Question: How does Kant construct antinomies to illustrate the illusory tendencies of pure reason? Explain and examine the antinomies presented by Kant.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Three limbs — construct, explain, examine ; the examination carries the marks

Element	Requirement
Core issue	The mechanism of construction, the four pairs, and the two resolutions
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: illusion, construction, four pairs stated compactly, classification, both resolutions, assessment
Ideal thesis	The antinomies expose a shared false premise and thereby serve as an indirect proof of transcendental idealism
Non-negotiables	Both proofs by <i>reductio</i> ; mathematical both false, dynamical both may be true; freedom is room, not proof

Independent model answer

Illusion first. Reason seeks the unconditioned, and the search is legitimate as a maxim of enquiry. Transcendental illusion is **natural and unavoidable**: criticism prevents deception but never dispels the appearance, as the moon still looks larger on the horizon to one who knows why.

Construction. Kant selects one cosmological Idea per category-group, applied to the world-series. Each side is proved **indirectly**, by *reductio* of its opposite, and both proofs are given their full force rather than caricatured. Both share one premise: that the world is a **given, completed whole** of which one of two contradictory predicates must hold. The conflict is therefore necessary, not careless — which is what makes it an argument against the premise rather than against either party.

The four pairs. First: the world has a beginning in time and limits in space — against: it is infinite in both. Second: composites consist of simple parts — against: nothing simple exists. Third: there is causality through freedom besides natural causality — against: everything happens by natural law alone. Fourth: an absolutely necessary being belongs to the world — against: no such being exists.

Classification. The first two are **mathematical**: the series is homogeneous, its members being of the same kind as the conditioned. The last two are **dynamical**: the condition need not be sensible at all.

The two resolutions. Mathematical: **both sides are false**. The world-whole is never given as complete, so it is neither finite nor infinite; the regress may always be continued. Dynamical: **both may be true**. Natural determination holds of appearances, while spontaneous causality remains thinkable of the same agent considered as noumenon; and no necessary being need occur within the series, though an intelligible ground is not thereby contradicted.

Examination. 🚩 Freedom is made **thinkable**, not proved: theoretical reason establishes only that spontaneous causality involves no contradiction. The antinomies show that speculative metaphysics of the supersensible cannot be a science, and they motivate the confinement of knowledge to phenomena. Above all they function as an **indirect proof** of transcendental idealism: realism about appearances generates the contradictions and idealism dissolves them, so a doctrine argued analytically earlier is here vindicated by its explanatory yield.

Verdict. ? Powerful but not decisive — the proof works only if no third diagnosis exists, and Hegel offers one: contradiction as productive rather than pathological.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2022 Q3(a): "examine" is the marked limb. A list of four antinomies without resolutions answers a different question.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: illusion in two lines; construction in five; pairs in five; classification in three; resolutions in five; examination in four; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** illusion → construction → four pairs → classification → two resolutions → examination → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** regulative versus constitutive; homogeneous versus heterogeneous series.
- **Evidence:** the double *reductio*; the shared premise.
- **Distinction:** both false versus both may be true.
- **Criticism:** the indirect proof with its stated limit.

2023 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: "Precepts without concepts are blind and concepts without precepts are empty." In the light of this statement discuss how Kant reconciles rationalism with empiricism.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"In the light of this statement... discuss" — locate the sentence, then use it
Core issue	The reconciliation, exhibited through the quoted formula
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the wording note, both halves, the two stems, one closing restriction
Ideal thesis	Content from sensibility and form from understanding — a division of labour, not a compromise
Non-negotiables	Quote as printed, restore A51/B75, note the substitution, then answer

Independent model answer

⚠ **Wording note.** The paper prints "Precepts" twice. Kant's own formulation is: "Thoughts without content are empty, intuitions without concepts are blind" (A51/B75). "Precepts" stands where "intuitions" should stand, and the halves are transposed. The point of the sentence is unaffected.

The two halves. *Thoughts without content are empty* corrects **rationalism**: a concept for which no corresponding intuition is even possible determines no object. *Intuitions without concepts are blind* corrects **empiricism**: an unsynthesised manifold is not yet perception of an *object*, since without a rule there is nothing to be right or wrong about.

The reconciliation. Human cognition has **two stems**: sensibility, receptive, supplying content under the forms of space and time, and understanding, spontaneous, supplying rules through the categories. "The understanding can intuit nothing, and the senses can think nothing." Knowledge is their union.

This is not a fifty-fifty compromise. Kant sides with the empiricist about the **source of content** and with the rationalist about the **source of necessity**, which is possible only because he has separated the two questions.

Verdict. ⚠️ The reconciliation is bought by restricting the categories to possible experience — so it is simultaneously an anti-metaphysical verdict.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2023 Q1(a): handle the printed wording in two sentences, then answer the question actually asked. Never silently correct the paper.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: wording note in three lines; two halves in four; reconciliation in four; verdict in one.

- **Structure:** wording note → both halves → two stems → the non-compromise → restriction.
- **Doctrine:** receptivity and spontaneity; A51/B75.
- **Evidence:** the quoted formula and the "can intuit nothing" sentence.
- **Distinction:** content versus necessity, separated in Session 2.
- **Criticism:** the closing restriction turns a summary into an argument.

2023 · Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: What are the main arguments offered by Kant to prove that apriori synthetic judgements are possible? Discuss with examples.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Main arguments... with examples" — plural, and each example must be argued
Core issue	Why each showcase is both synthetic and a priori, and how the possibility is explained
Scope boundary	Ten marks: three domains, one line of argument each, then the explanation
Ideal thesis	Kant exhibits instances and then explains their possibility by the conformity of objects to our forms
Non-negotiables	The reason each case is synthetic; the reason each is a priori; the Copernican explanation

Independent model answer

Kant does not postulate the class; he exhibits instances and then asks how they are possible.

Arithmetic. " $7 + 5 = 12$ " is **synthetic**: the concept of the sum contains only the thought of uniting the two numbers, not twelve, which must be brought in by counting in pure intuition. It is **a priori**: no experiment could falsify it and it admits no exception.

Geometry. "The straight line between two points is the shortest" is **synthetic**: "straight" is a quality, "shortest" a quantity, and no analysis of the first yields the second. It is **a priori**: it is constructed in pure spatial intuition.

Fundamental natural science. "Every event has a cause" is **synthetic**: the concept of something that begins to be does not contain a determining antecedent. It is **a priori**: it cannot be induced without circularity, since objective time-order presupposes it.

How they are possible. Because objects, *as objects of possible experience*, conform to our a priori forms — space, time and the categories — what those forms contribute is necessarily valid of everything that can appear.

Verdict. ⚠ Metaphysics *aspires* to this class and fails, which is why the argument that vindicates mathematics closes speculative theology.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2023 Q1(e): each example needs two clauses — why synthetic, why a priori. Listing examples without arguing them answers half the question.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: one line of framing; three examples in nine; explanation in three; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** framing → three worked examples → the Copernican explanation → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** ampliative versus explicative; necessity and strict universality.
- **Evidence:** the three showcases, each with its argument.
- **Distinction:** metaphysics aspires to the class and fails.
- **Criticism:** the honest note about non-Euclidean geometry.

2024 · Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: How does Kant respond to Hume's scepticism with regard to a priori judgments? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does... respond" — locate the exact point of disagreement
Core issue	What Kant concedes to Hume and what he denies
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the fork, the concession, the Second Analogy, the size of the victory
Ideal thesis	Kant accepts Hume's analysis of experience and denies his conclusion by relocating necessity
Non-negotiables	The missing third time; the concession; entitlement versus particular laws

Independent model answer

Hume's position. Enquiry divides into relations of ideas, known a priori and trivially, and matters of fact, known only from experience. No impression of necessary connexion is found, so causal necessity is a felt determination of the mind — custom, not reason.

Kant's concession. ✅ Kant grants Hume's analysis of *experience* entirely: no observed regularity yields necessity, and there is no impression of causal power. The dispute is not about impressions.

Kant's denial. The fork is **not exhaustive**. "Every event has a cause" is ampliative and yet necessary. The response is a change of standpoint: if objects, as objects of possible experience, conform to our forms, then what those forms contribute holds necessarily of every appearance.

The mechanism. In the Second Analogy, time itself cannot be perceived, and apprehension is successive whether I survey a house or watch a ship drift. The difference between subjective sequence and objective event lies in the **necessity of the order**, which requires a rule — the concept of cause (A189).

Verdict. ⚠️ Kant wins the **entitlement** to the concept of cause; he does not deliver particular causal connections, which remain empirical. Causality is valid of appearances only, so the same argument forbids inferring a first cause.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2024 Q1(b): name the concession explicitly. A script that presents Kant as refuting Hume's account of impressions has misidentified the disagreement.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: Hume in four lines; concession in two; denial in three; mechanism in four; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** Hume → concession → denial → mechanism → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the fork; synthetic a priori; the Second Analogy.
- **Evidence:** the house and the ship; A189.
- **Distinction:** entitlement versus particular causal laws.
- **Criticism:** the closing restriction to appearances is the assessment.

2024 · Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: Critically examine Kant's objections against the ontological argument for the existence of God.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	" Critically examine" — the assessment limb is compulsory
Core issue	The objections, their reach, and what survives them
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the objection, the corollary, the dependency chain, the modern assessment
Ideal thesis	Devastating against the Cartesian and Anselmian forms; contested against modal reconstructions
Non-negotiables	"Real predicate" glossed; the contradiction corollary; Malcolm and Plantinga; the quantifier point

Independent model answer

The objections. First and principally: "being is obviously not a real predicate" (A598/B626). ⚠️ *Real* means **content-adding**, a determination that enlarges a concept. Existence does not enlarge a concept; it **posits** its object as actual. A hundred real thalers contain not the least coin more than a hundred possible thalers.

Second, the corollary about contradiction. The argument requires that denying God's existence be self-contradictory. But if subject and predicate are rejected together, nothing remains to conflict. Contradiction arises only when a subject is retained and one of its genuine predicates denied.

Third, the structural objection. Because the cosmological proof must identify its necessary being with the most real being, and the physico-theological proof must borrow an infinite cause, **all three proofs terminate in the ontological argument** — so one refutation is sufficient for all.

Critical assessment. The objection is widely judged **devastating** against the Cartesian and Anselmian formulations, and it changed the shape of the debate permanently. ❓ It is contested whether it reaches **modal** versions: Malcolm and Plantinga argue that treating *necessary existence*, rather than bare existence, as the relevant predicate escapes Kant's diagnosis, and the reply is that necessary existence may be a modal operator rather than a determination.

A further consideration strengthens Kant. If existence is not a predicate, what is it? His answer — that it is positing — was later formalised in the logic of the existential quantifier, so his objection is generally judged **vindicated** rather than superseded.

Verdict. ⚠️ Decisive against the classical form; unsettled against its modal descendants — and in neither case a proof that God does not exist.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2024 Q2(c): the word "critically" makes the modal debate compulsory. Refuting and stopping forfeits the assessment mark.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: three objections in nine lines; assessment in five; verdict in one.

- **Structure:** three objections → assessment → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** positing versus determining; the dependency chain.
- **Evidence:** A598/B626; the thalers; Malcolm and Plantinga.
- **Distinction:** classical versus modal formulations.
- **Criticism:** the quantifier vindication is the strongest available close.

2026 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: Analyze and discuss the different ways in which Kant and Hegel conceived the relationship between reality and our thinking about reality.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Analyze and discuss" — reconstruct both positions, compare their mechanisms, then judge
Core issue	Whether thought supplies only the conditions of phenomenal objectivity or articulates reality itself
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: Kant's settlement, Hegel's three corrections, explicit axes and a graded verdict
Ideal thesis	Hegel inherits Kant's constitutive turn but rejects its fixed dualisms and unknowable remainder
Non-negotiables	empirical realism/transcendental idealism; categories; thing in itself; dialectic; culmination and overcoming

Independent model answer

Kant and Hegel agree against naïve realism that thought is not a passive copy of a wholly ready-made world. They differ over the **range** and **movement** of thought's contribution.

For Kant, sensibility receives a manifold under the pure forms of space and time; understanding synthesises it through a fixed table of categories under the transcendental unity of apperception. Therefore the conditions of possible experience are conditions of its objects: the understanding "makes nature" **formally considered** as a law-governed unity of appearances. Yet this constitutive role is restricted. We know only phenomena, while the thing in itself remains a negative limiting concept. Kant thus combines **empirical realism** with **transcendental idealism**: experienced objects are public and objective, but their necessary form is form-for-us.

Hegel accepts the constitutive insight but rejects Kant's fixed separations. Categories are not merely subjective forms imposed on a supplied manifold; they are determinations through which reality itself becomes intelligible. Nor are they a static table borrowed from formal logic: each category generates tensions that lead dialectically to a richer one. Consequently, appearance and reality, thought and being, finite and infinite cannot remain externally opposed. The Absolute is not an unknowable beyond but a self-developing whole that comes to know itself through finite consciousness.

The gain is unity: Hegel removes the unexplained affection of sensibility by a thing in itself and makes contradiction productive. The cost is stronger metaphysical ambition; Kant would regard knowledge of the Absolute as precisely the transcendent use criticism forbids.

Verdict. ⚠️ Hegel is Kant's culmination in treating thought as constitutive, but his overcoming in extending that claim from possible experience to reality as a whole.

Qualification and criticism

Hegel's charge exposes the instability of an unknowable remainder, but abolishing the boundary risks turning the structure of thought into the structure of being without an independently secured deduction.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2026 Q4(b): compare on explicit axes — source, status and range of categories; phenomenon/noumenon; role of contradiction; knowability of the Absolute — rather than writing two isolated summaries.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: agreement in two lines; Kant in six; Hegel in six; gain/cost in three; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** common starting point → Kantian settlement → Hegelian correction → gain/cost → graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** transcendental idealism, empirical realism, categories, thing in itself, dialectical development, Absolute.
- **Evidence:** “Understanding makes Nature” as formally restricted; Hegel's rejection of fixed dualisms.
- **Qualification:** the answer grants Hegel's internal criticism without treating speculative idealism as automatically established.

2026 cross-link — Q2(b), primarily owned by Empiricism

Exact verified wording: “How does Hume account for ideas of reason? How does Kant respond to Hume’s views in this regard? Critically discuss.”

The complete answer is owned and solved in the [Empiricism toolkit](#). For a Kant revision spine: concede that experience yields no impression of necessary connexion; reject habit as sufficient for objective event-order; introduce causality as a category mediated by its temporal schema; use the Second Analogy to distinguish apprehended sequence from objective succession; restrict validity to phenomena. This cross-link does **not** add to Kant's primary-owner count.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Six original questions in the UPSC idiom — two at 10 marks, two at 15 and two at 20 — with complete model answers inside the declared bands. These are learner practice, not past papers.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish between the transcendental and the transcendent in Kant, and explain why the distinction is indispensable to the Transcendental Dialectic. Discuss.

Independent model answer

The distinction. *Transcendental* names an enquiry into the a priori **conditions** under which objects can be given to us. It is legitimate and unavoidable; the deduction of the categories and the unity of apperception are transcendental. *Transcendent* names the employment of concepts **beyond** all possible experience. It is illegitimate, because a category has objective sense only through its schema, and a schema is a determination of time.

Why the Dialectic requires it. Reason's principle — that for every conditioned the whole series of conditions is given — is a **regulative** maxim directing enquiry toward systematic unity. Read constitutively, it becomes a claim about an existing unconditioned object, and the enquiry becomes transcendent.

Each of the three collapses is then a specific transcendent move. The Paralogisms convert a formal condition of thought into a soul-substance. The Antinomies treat the world-series as a given whole. The Ideal hypostatizes a standard of complete determination into an existing most real being.

⚠️ **Kant's distinctive claim.** Transcendental illusion is **natural and unavoidable**, unlike a logical mistake that vanishes once exposed. Criticism prevents us from being deceived; it does not make the appearance disappear.

Verdict. ⚠️ Without the distinction the Dialectic has no diagnosis — only a list of failed proofs.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Explain Kant's doctrine of the schematism and state precisely why the schemata must be determinations of time. Discuss.

Independent model answer

The problem. Subsumption normally requires **homogeneity**: the concept *plate* and a round dish share roundness. But categories are pure and intellectual while appearances are sensible, so they are **heterogeneous**. The Deduction proved that categories must apply; it did not show how.

The solution. A **third thing** (*ein Drittes*) is required — intellectual in one respect, sensible in another. That is the **transcendental schema**, produced by the productive imagination, and every schema is a **determination of time**.

Why time. The mediator must be universal and a priori, like the category, and contained in every appearance, like intuition. Time alone satisfies both: it is a pure a priori form and the form of **inner** sense, so every representation is in time. Space fails that test.

Schema, not image. Any drawn triangle is determinately scalene or equilateral; the schema is the **rule** for constructing a triangle in general.

Consequence. Without its schema a category is a mere logical function: it can be **thought** but determines no object — which is why the negative noumenon is thinkable.

Verdict. ⚠️ Kant calls the procedure "an art concealed in the depths of the human soul" (A141/B180–1): the joint that carries the system is the one he cannot display.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "The Second Analogy defeats Hume at the level of entitlement but not at the level of knowledge." Examine this claim.

Independent model answer

The claim's first half. Hume argued that no impression of necessary connexion is available, so the concept of cause is a product of custom. Kant grants the analysis and denies the conclusion. His master premise is that **time itself cannot be perceived** (A176/B219), so objective temporal relations must be established by rules found among appearances.

The argument runs: apprehension is successive in every case; I nevertheless distinguish surveying a house, where the order is **reversible** and mine to choose, from watching a ship drift downstream, where it is **irreversible**. That difference cannot lie in succession itself, nor be read off unperceivable time; it lies in the **necessity** of the order, which requires a rule — "everything that happens presupposes something upon which it follows according to a rule" (A189). The concept of cause is therefore a condition of experiencing an objective event.

The claim's second half. Kant never derives which causes operate. That bread nourishes, that this collision produces that motion, remain empirical discoveries. The Analogy secures the **form** of nature and leaves the **content** to science.

Verdict. ⚠️ The claim is accurate. Kant wins the entitlement Hume denied and declines the knowledge Hume demanded — which is not an evasion but a consequence of separating form from content. ? Strawson calls the central transition a "non-sequitur of numbing grossness", since that the order of my perceptions is not up to me does not entail that the event is necessitated by a causal law; Guyer argues that at most *some* rule is required. Allison replies that Kant is describing the conditions under which a succession can be **judged** objective, and that only a causal rule can fix an irreversible position in one time. The restriction to appearances then follows: the same argument that defeats Hume forbids inferring a first cause of the world.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Assess the view that Kant's phenomena–noumena distinction is an empty boundary that his own system cannot sustain.

Independent model answer

The charge. Two objections combine. **Hegel** argues that the unknowable in-itself is an empty abstraction produced by fixing a permanent opposition between appearance and reality. **Jacobi** presses the affection problem: "without the assumption of things in themselves I cannot enter the system; with it I cannot remain" — for if causality is a category valid only of appearances, Kant cannot say that things in themselves cause our sensations.

The reply. Kant's noumenon in the **negative** sense is a *limiting concept* (*Grenzbegriff*): something considered merely as **not** an object of our sensible intuition. Its emptiness is deliberate, since a boundary that had content would no longer be a boundary. A noumenon in the **positive** sense would require intellectual intuition, which Kant expressly denies we possess. The Schematism supplies the ground: a category without a schema can be **thought** but determines no object, which is exactly what "thinkable but not knowable" means.

Against Hegel, the distinction is therefore not a knowledge-claim about a hidden object; against Jacobi, Kant's language is more careful than the objection allows — he speaks of what **affects** sensibility without claiming theoretical cognition of a noumenal cause.

What survives the reply. ? The affection problem is a genuine tension, not a misreading. The **two-aspect** reading, on which the same objects are considered under two epistemic standpoints, reduces the pressure by making affection an aspect of one cognitive relation rather than a transaction between worlds; but the textual dispute with the two-world reading remains live.

Verdict. ⚠️ The boundary is not empty in the pejorative sense: it does indispensable work, licensing the Principles for everything that can appear and forbidding their extension to soul, world and God. It is, however, a boundary Kant can state more securely than he can explain — and that is the honest formulation.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "Kant's Transcendental Deduction is the strongest anti-sceptical argument in modern philosophy and rests on its weakest scaffolding." Critically examine.

Independent model answer

The strength. The Deduction asks the sceptic to concede almost nothing: that his representations are **his**. Kant's premise is that "the *I think* must be able to accompany all my representations" (B131–2); otherwise something would be represented in me that could not be thought, and would be nothing for me.

From that premise: combination "can never come to us through the senses", since sensibility is receptive and delivers a manifold but never its unity; every synthesis is an act of spontaneity. A manifold can belong to **one** consciousness only if combined in a determinate, repeatable way — that is, according to rules. Those rules are the categories, since a category just is the concept of a synthesis in accordance with a logical function of judgement. And an object is "that in the concept of which the manifold of a given intuition is united". Hence the categories are necessarily valid of every object of possible experience.

This is anti-scepticism without a premise the sceptic can refuse. It simultaneously answers Hume, who sought the self among impressions and found none because the "I think" is a condition and not a content, and rational psychology, which converted the same formal unity into a substance.

The weakness. The **metaphysical** deduction supplies the inventory: twelve categories read off twelve logical functions of judgement, on the premise that the understanding is a faculty of judging. Fichte, Hegel and later Kantians object that the derivation is artificial and the completeness claim rests entirely on the logic Kant inherited. Kant's defence — that the table of judgements is exhaustive and systematic, and that no more complete rival was offered — is a defence of the best available list, not a proof.

Adjudication. ⚠️ The two are separable. The Deduction's **strategy** is that objectivity is a *condition* rather than a *discovery*; its **inventory** is a historical contingency. Strawson's austere reading detaches the strategy and preserves the result. ? There is a further dispute — whether the A and B versions argue differently or only differ in exposition — but it concerns route and emphasis rather than the core claim.

Verdict. ⚠️ The statement is accurate as it stands. The argument survives the loss of the table; the table would not survive the loss of the argument. Its remaining cost is scope: the conclusion holds of objects **as they can be given to us**, so the Deduction secures objectivity within possible experience and leaves things in themselves untouched.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Examine Kant's claim that all three speculative proofs for the existence of God fail together, and assess what his critique leaves standing.

Independent model answer

The structural claim. God, as the most real being (*ens realissimum*), lies beyond possible experience, and the categories have objective employment only through their schemata and hence only within experience. Kant then adds an exhaustiveness claim: there are only **three** speculative routes — from the mere concept (ontological), from the existence of anything at all (cosmological), and from the determinate order of nature (physico-theological).

Ontological. "Being is obviously not a real predicate" (A598/B626), where *real* means content-adding. Existence does not enlarge a concept; it **posits** its object as actual — a hundred real thalers contain not the least coin more than a hundred possible thalers. Nor is denying God's existence self-contradictory: if subject and predicate are rejected together, nothing remains to conflict.

Cosmological. Two blows. It misapplies **causality** beyond possible experience, since the totality of existents is not an event in time and the schema of cause is succession according to a rule *in* time. More decisively, identifying the necessary being with the most real being presupposes that the concept of the most real being includes necessary existence — which **is** the ontological argument. Kant calls the proof a "nest of dialectical assumptions".

Physico-theological. ✅ Kant treats it with respect as the oldest and clearest proof. But a finite effect licenses only a proportionate cause: at best an **architect** who orders pre-existing material, not a creator. To reach an infinite creator it must borrow an infinite or necessary cause — the cosmological proof — which in turn presupposes the ontological.

The chain. Design → cosmological → ontological → fails. One refutation, three casualties.

What survives. Theoretical reason can neither prove nor disprove God: Kant is **agnostic, not atheistic**. Practical reason then **postulates** God, since the highest good requires a being able to proportion happiness to virtue — "I had to deny knowledge in order to make room for faith" (Bxxx; *Glaube* is rendered "belief" by Guyer–Wood). ⚠️ Freedom and immortality are postulated on parallel grounds, and the argument stops there: Kantian ethics as a doctrine is not printed in this syllabus item.

Verdict. ❓ The critique is decisive against the classical formulations and contested against modal reconstructions by Malcolm and Plantinga. What Kant leaves standing is not a diminished theology but a **relocated** one: God ceases to be an object of proof and becomes a condition of the moral life — at the price of conceding that theology can never be a science.